

SOLIDWORKS PDM: questions for the install

What SDI Intelligence needs to know about PDM before the software side is built on it: reaching the database, the vault and its local cache, versions and revisions, and how our tools follow a file. Take it to the reseller and Ian, and write the answers in the boxes.

These answers are also the evidence for the **end-of-October go/no-go between PDM Standard and the SDI Design Vault**. That decision turns on whether the estimating tools, Drawing Search, Sage, QC and the AI can reach the design data through PDM.

Prepared by James Gray · SDI Intelligence · 30 September 2026 · for the reseller, Ian, Jack and Yogesh

First meeting: the six to settle

1. PDM Standard or Professional, and what an outside program may do with it, in writing.
2. A read-only database login for SDI Intelligence.
3. A PDM licence and a local vault view for the runner account on the new server.
4. Which workflow state counts as "released" for estimating.
5. The list of data-card variables.
6. The migration plan and date for the K: drive.

1 · Product and version

Standard and Professional differ most in what other software can reach, and everything below depends on which one this is.

- ☐ **Is it PDM Standard or PDM Professional, and which year's release?**

ASK: RESELLER

- ☐ **What can an outside program do with it?** Read file properties, get a file and its references, list versions, be told when a file is checked in.

Ask for this in writing for the exact product. PDM Standard's automation interface is more limited than Professional's.

ASK: RESELLER

- ☐ **Is there a route from Standard to Professional later, and what would it cost?**

ASK: RESELLER

2 · The database

Search and reporting tools usually read the PDM database directly. That is common practice, but Dassault does not support it and the table layout can change between versions.

- ☐ **Which SQL Server edition and version, on which machine?**

PDM Standard runs on SQL Server Express, which caps a database at 10 GB.

ASK: RESELLER / JACK

- ☐ **What are the vault and database names?**

ASK: RESELLER

- ☐ **Can SDI Intelligence have a read-only SQL login?**

ASK: RESELLER / JACK

- ☐ **Will we be told before an upgrade that changes the database layout?**

ASK: RESELLER

- ☐ **How large is the database expected to grow, and what happens near the 10 GB cap?**

ASK: RESELLER

3 · Where the files live: vault, archive and local cache

The vault keeps files in an archive under internal numbered names. People and programs work on copies in a local vault view. Our tools must never read or write the archive directly.

- ☐ **Where do the archive server and its storage sit?**

ASK: RESELLER / JACK

- ☐ **Can the runner account on the new server have its own vault login and local view?**

The estimating runner and Drawing Search read files through a view like any user.

ASK: RESELLER / JACK

- ☐ **How big does the local cache get, where does it live, and how is it cleared?**

ASK: RESELLER

4 · Versions and revisions

Every check-in makes a new version; a revision (A, B ...) is a label the workflow sets. Our quotes name a revision, so estimating needs to know which one it is reading.

- ☐ **What are the workflow states, and who moves a file between them?**

For example Work in progress → Approved → Released.

ASK: IAN

- ☐ **Which should estimating and Drawing Search read: the latest version, or the latest released revision?**

DECIDE: JAMES, IAN

- ☐ **What is the revision scheme, and when is a revision stamped on the file?**

ASK: IAN / RESELLER

- ☐ **Can an older version be fetched?**

A re-quote may need the exact revision that was quoted.

ASK: RESELLER

5 · Data cards

The variables on PDM's data cards map onto fields the engine currently reads off the drawings. Filled in reliably, they become a stronger source than the PDF text.

- ☐ **What variables are on the file and folder cards?** Drawing Number, Revision, Description, Material, Finish, Customer, Job, Drawn by ...

ASK: RESELLER / IAN

- ☐ **Are the card variables kept in step with the SOLIDWORKS custom properties, and in which direction?**

ASK: RESELLER

- ☐ **Which variables are mandatory at check-in?**

ASK: IAN

6 · References and "Get latest"

An assembly needs its referenced parts. Getting one file does not guarantee its references are local and current.

- ☐ **How should a program fetch a whole assembly with all its references at the right versions?**

ASK: RESELLER

- ☐ **How do cross-project and library parts behave?**

Yogesh has pinned this down with Ian; the Design Vault must match it.

CONFIRM: YOGESH, IAN

- ☐ **Where do drawings, DXFs and PDFs sit relative to their model?** Same folder, same name?

ASK: IAN

7 · Knowing when something changes

Drawing Search and the estimating tools need to stay current without re-reading every file.

- ☐ **How can another program learn that a file was checked in or a revision released?**

The options are PDM's own event hooks (more limited in Standard), reading recent changes from the database, or a scheduled export.

ASK: RESELLER

- ☐ **Is there an audit log of check-ins and state changes we can read?**

ASK: RESELLER

8 · File identity and fingerprints

Drawing Search tracks files by path and a file fingerprint (hash) today. In a vault the lasting identity is PDM's own document ID and version, and the path depends on each person's local view.

- ☐ **Does a file keep its document ID through rename, move and copy-tree?**

ASK: RESELLER

- ☐ **Can the document ID and version be read with each file?** Our indexes should key on these, not on the path.

ASK: RESELLER

- ☐ **How does PDM treat two identical files in different projects?**

ASK: RESELLER

9 · Migration from the K: drive

Our estimates read their packs from K: today, so the cut-over date matters to every tool.

- ☐ **What goes into the vault, and in what folder layout?**

ASK: IAN / RESELLER

- ☐ **What happens to the existing K: files: frozen, read-only, or kept in step?**

ASK: IAN / JACK

- ☐ **How are duplicates handled on import, and does history come across or does version 1 start at import?**

ASK: RESELLER

- ☐ **What is the cut-over date?**

ASK: IAN

10 · Licences and accounts

- ☐ **Does the runner or service account need its own PDM licence?**

ASK: RESELLER

- ☐ **Can that account be given read-only permissions across the vault?**

ASK: RESELLER / JACK

- ☐ **What happens to automated access when a user leaves or a password changes?**

ASK: JACK

11 · Operations

- ☐ **How are the database and archive backed up, and are they backed up together?**

ASK: JACK / RESELLER

☐ **Where do the PDM servers run in relation to the new SDI Intelligence server?**

ASK: JACK

☐ **How are PDM upgrades scheduled, and who tells SDI Intelligence first?**

ASK: RESELLER / JACK

What the answers decide: whether SDI Intelligence reads PDM through its database, its automation interface or a scheduled export; how Drawing Search and the estimating runner key their records; and whether PDM Standard can do what the SDI Design Vault was built to do by the end-of-October go/no-go.